neighborhood had turned into a jumble of malls, shops and apartment blocks. The few remaining bungalows now hide fearfully amidst the new buildings.

THE STEAM MONSTERS

By 1820, India's population stood at 111 million, but its share in world GDP had fallen to 16 per cent compared to China's 33 per cent. [13] Together they still accounted for half of the global economy, but China was doing most of the heavy lifting. Driven by the Industrial Revolution, Britain already enjoyed a per capita income that was three times higher than that of the Asian giants. As the nineteenth century wore on, the gap between the Europeans and the Asians grew wider. By the time India became independent in 1947, its share would fall to a mere 4 per cent of world GDP.

Despite this relative decline, the second half of the nineteenth century witnessed a radical transformation of the country's economic and geographic landscape. The introduction of the railways was arguably the single most important factor that drove this change. Both commercial and military considerations lay behind the idea of building a railway network. Through the 1830s and 1840s, there were a number of discussions and proposals. The government did not have internal resources to build it but it was initially thought that private operators would easily raise the capital. However, it was soon clear that the money could not be raised in India. Investors in England also appeared lukewarm.

The discussions drifted for several years till the arrival of F.W. Simms, a railway engineer of 'tried and proved ability'. A number of routes were surveyed under his supervision. He argued that a Delhi–Calcutta line would allow the military establishment alone to make a saving of at least 50,000 pounds a year, a very large sum in those days. [14] Given these encouraging studies, the government decided to give generous guarantees to persuade investors to pump capital into the railways. These included a guaranteed return of 4.5 per cent as well as an exchange rate guarantee. These would later prove expensive and attract a lot of criticism, but at that moment they